

COINCIDENCE OR WHAT? (Left) Mamata Banerjee speaking at the Opposition conclave in Bengaluru; the NDA meet in Delhi, July 18

Modi gave a new definition to NDA—New India, Development and Aspirations of the People—driven by "pure intent, a clear policy and decisiveness" while calling the Opposition alliance a "conclave of the corrupt" whose mantra is "of, by, and for the family". Though officially held to celebrate 25 years of the NDA, there was no masking the electoral imperative as it was the first such gathering of the NDA allies since coming to power a second time in 2019.

Beyond this electoral rhetoric and show of strength, both alliances, however, have not yet found electorally meaningful formulas to take the arithmetic and chemistry of their coming together to a logical conclusion. Of the 38 NDA parties, 25 did not win a single seat in the 2019 Lok Sabha election. If the Eknath Shinde faction of the Shiv Sena and the Ajit Pawar-led Nationalist Congress Party are excluded, other non-BJP allies account for only 15 seats across the country, including five from the Northeast. Similarly, 11 of the 26 INDIA partners have no representation in the Lok Sabha. But the strength of these alliances lies in protecting smaller turfs for larger electoral gains. Take, for instance, the BJP's alliance with the NISHAD party, led by the eponymous Nishad community leader Sanjay Nishad. Though the party has zero presence in the Lok Sabha, its support ensured that Praveen Nishad, son of Sanjay, won the 2019 Lok Sabha seat on a BJP ticket. Similarly, 14 of the 26 INDIA parties that won at least one Lok Sabha seat in 2019 cornered nearly 35 per cent of the vote share. If the vote share of the rump Sena and NCP factions and 10 other parties are added, it could well go past the BJP's 37 per cent vote share in 2019. Though elections are scarcely won on plain arithmetic, smart seat-sharing among the Opposition parties can potentially dent the BJP's mammoth tally of 303 in 2019.

THE OPPOSITION IS HOPING TO MAKE 2024 A BATTLE OF THEIR IDEA OF INDIA VERSUS NARENDRA MODI'S BJP

GAME OF PERCEPTIONS

Besides, alliances are also about building electoral perceptions. The gathering of 26 parties in Bengaluru offered the first hint of how the Opposition plans to blunt Modi and the BJP's edge in 2024. It will be on an issue perceived to have given the BJP an electoral advantage in the previous two general elections—nationalism. The Opposition parties believe that the BJP camp, with its superlative ability to package and promote any message, has successfully used the emotional appeal of nationalism to build a narrative in which it projects itself as the sole custodian of the national interest and paints its rivals as anti-national. Modi also leaves no opportunity to call members of rival formations opportunists and corrupt, who think nothing of defaming India outside the country but who are now trying to save their existence and their families. The BJP, on the other hand,